

Mediterranean Chicken Pasta

Savory penne tossed with a tomato-spinach sauce and topped with grilled Italian chicken, feta, and fresh parsley.

Ingredients

- 16 ounces penne pasta
- 6 tablespoons olive oil
- 1 medium onion, diced
- 4 teaspoons minced garlic
- 1 28-ounce can San Marzano-style crushed tomatoes
- 2 teaspoons chopped fresh basil
- 1 teaspoon dried oregano
- 2 cups fresh spinach, coarsely chopped
- 2 boneless, skinless chicken breasts
- Garlic salt, to taste
- Black pepper, to taste
- Italian seasoning, to taste
- 8 ounces feta cheese, crumbled
- Fresh parsley, chopped, for garnish
- Salt, for the pasta water and sauce

Instructions

1. Season the chicken breasts with garlic salt, black pepper, and Italian seasoning.
2. Grill the chicken until the thickest part reaches 165°F on a food thermometer.
3. Rest the chicken breasts whole for about 5 minutes.
4. Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil. Cook the penne until al dente, reserving some pasta water before draining.
5. While the pasta cooks, heat the olive oil in a large skillet over medium heat.
6. Add the diced onion and saute until softened.
7. Add the minced garlic and saute briefly, just until fragrant.
8. Add the crushed tomatoes, basil, and oregano. Season with salt and black pepper, then simmer on low for 15 to 20 minutes, stirring occasionally.
9. Nestle the rested chicken breasts into the tomato sauce, spoon sauce over the top, and let them warm through briefly. Remove the chicken and slice it into bite-size pieces.
10. Raise the heat to medium. Add the spinach and cook for 30 to 60 seconds, just until wilted.
11. Stir in a splash of reserved pasta water to loosen the sauce.
12. Add the drained penne and toss until evenly coated, then remove the skillet from the heat.
13. Divide the pasta among wide bowls. Top with the sliced chicken, crumbled feta, and fresh parsley.

Cook's Notes

Do not overcook the spinach; it needs only enough heat to wilt. Add the reserved pasta water a little at a time until the sauce reaches the consistency you want. The chicken goes back into the sauce only briefly so it can warm through and pick up the tomato flavor before slicing.

Chicken is safely cooked when the thickest part reaches 165°F as measured with a food thermometer.